

**Domesticity As Battleground: A Comparative Study of Marital
Conflict, Gender Justice, and Social Reform in the Fiction of Prof.
Vikas Sharma and Arundhati Roy**

A Synopsis

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ABSTRACT

The present research proposes a comparative study of selected fictional and non-fictional works by Prof. Vikas Sharma and Arundhati Roy, with the central contention that the domestic space in contemporary Indian English literature functions as a zone of ongoing contestation rather than safety or refuge. The study reads the Indian household as an institution in which marital discord, gendered suffering, and the uneven outcomes of legal intervention are negotiated and reproduced through everyday life. Three novels by Dr. Vikas Sharma, namely *498A: Fears and Dreams*, *Ashes and Fire*, and *Love's Not Time's Fool*, are examined alongside three works by Arundhati Roy, namely *The God of Small Things*, *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness*, and *My Seditious Heart*, to investigate how two writers positioned very differently within Indian literary culture nonetheless converge on shared questions about what marriage costs women, how law enters and reshapes the household, and what possibilities for resistance or reform the domestic interior permits.

The theoretical foundation of the study rests on three interconnected traditions. Feminist theory, particularly the work of Judith Butler on gender as a performed and policed set of behaviours, and Nivedita Menon on the Indian family as a political rather than purely private institution, provides the conceptual vocabulary for reading gender dynamics in both bodies of fiction. Postcolonial feminist criticism, drawn primarily from the scholarship of Rajeswari Sunder Rajan, situates these dynamics within the broader history of the Indian state's ambivalent governance of women. Feminist legal studies, anchored in the ethnographic research of Srimati Basu and the advocacy scholarship of Flavia Agnes, connects the fictional representation of law to the material reality of how legal provisions such as Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code operate in practice inside Indian families and courts.

The study identifies four significant gaps in existing scholarship. Critical work on Dr Vikas Sharma has remained largely descriptive and theoretically underdeveloped, confined to character analysis and surface legal commentary without engaging the feminist and legal frameworks that the fiction demands. Recent scholarship on Arundhati Roy has concentrated on transgender identity, ecological politics, and state violence, allowing the domestic and marital dimensions of her fiction to receive comparatively little sustained attention. No published work has brought these two authors into a single comparative frame. Finally, no study in Indian English literary criticism has combined close literary reading with feminist

legal scholarship across the fiction of a male and a female contemporary author writing about the same institutional terrain.

By addressing each of these gaps through a thematically organised comparative analysis, the thesis aims to produce four outcomes: a theoretically grounded reading of Sharma's fiction that does not yet exist in the field; a renewed critical attention to Roy's treatment of the household and marriage; a comparative model applicable to future studies of male and female authors writing on shared social questions; and a methodological example of interdisciplinary work at the junction of literary criticism and feminist legal studies. The study ultimately argues that reading these two writers together, one who writes the home from the inside and one who writes it against a wider political horizon, reveals dimensions of gender, law, and social reform in Indian domestic life that neither writer discloses alone.

INTRODUCTION

The Indian home has long been imagined as a place of safety, belonging, and continuity. Inside its walls, marriage is the central institution that organises kinship, property, reputation, and intimacy. Literature in India has often returned to this domestic interior to ask uncomfortable questions about who holds power within it and what happens to those who do not. The home appears in fiction not only as a setting but as a structure of feeling, an arrangement of rooms that carry memory, hierarchy, and silence. The present study reads two contemporary writers, Dr Vikas Sharma and Arundhati Roy, to argue that domesticity in modern Indian fiction is best understood as a battleground where marital conflict, gendered injury, and the contradictions of law and reform are played out in everyday life.

Sharma and Roy come from very different positions in the Indian literary field. Sharma writes from within an academic and middle-class milieu, often working close to the surface of contemporary social anxieties about marriage, dowry, and the use and misuse of legal protections such as Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code. His novels are concerned with the texture of ordinary married life, the disputes that build inside families, and the way the law enters bedrooms, kitchens, and courtrooms. Roy, in contrast, is read internationally as a literary stylist and a public intellectual whose fiction and political essays question the foundations of the Indian state, caste, capitalism, and patriarchy. Her novels treat the home as one site among many where larger structures of power can be felt on the skin. Reading them together is unusual, and that is part of the point.

The reason to place these two writers side by side is not to flatten the differences between them but to use those differences productively. Sharma writes the home from the inside, with a focus on its legal and emotional weather. Roy writes the home from a wider angle that places it within caste, history, and the long aftermath of colonial and postcolonial governance. Both, however, return to the question of what marriage does to women, what it costs them, what languages they find to speak about that cost, and what role law and reform play in either protecting or further constraining them. Looking at these writers together brings out something that neither one shows alone: the way the Indian home is at once an emotional space, a legal space, a caste structured space, and a political space.

The study takes the home as its starting point because so much of the violence and negotiation that shapes women's lives in India happens there rather than in obviously public arenas.

Domestic violence, dowry harassment, marital rape, custody disputes, the policing of women's sexuality, and the everyday work of reputation management all sit inside the household. At the same time, the home is also where resistance often begins, in small refusals, departures, silences, and acts of care that fall outside the script. Fiction is a particularly useful medium for examining this terrain because it can hold both the structural and the intimate at once. A novel can show a courtroom and a kitchen on the same page and let the reader see how one shapes the other.

A second reason this comparison matters is the question of law. Section 498A, which addresses cruelty by husbands and in laws, has become one of the most debated provisions of Indian criminal law. Public discussion swings between two positions, one that sees the section as an essential shield for women in violent marriages and another that sees it as a tool of misuse. Sharma's *498A: Fears and Dreams* enters this debate directly through fiction, while Roy's writing approaches law as a wider apparatus that often fails the very people it claims to protect. Putting these two engagements together allows the study to examine how literature thinks about legal reform, not as a finished achievement but as a contested, uneven, and sometimes painful process that is lived out in households long before it is settled in courtrooms.

A third reason is that the existing scholarship has not made this connection. Sharma has been read, where he has been read at all, as a chronicler of contemporary middle class anxieties, with most criticism staying at the level of plot summary, character psychology, or narrow legal commentary. Roy has been read very widely, but the focus in recent criticism has shifted towards transgender identity, state violence, and ecological politics, with the domestic interior of marriage receiving less attention than it once did. No study has yet brought these two writers into the same frame. The present work proposes that doing so opens up a way of thinking about Indian fiction in which the home, the law, and the question of gender justice are held together rather than separated into different specialisms.

The argument that organises the chapters that follow can be stated simply. The Indian home in the fiction of Sharma and Roy is a battleground. It is where marital conflict takes place, where gendered injury is inflicted and survived, where law arrives both as protection and as further harm, and where the slow, uneven work of social reform is tested against the grain of everyday life. The study traces this battleground across six primary texts, three by Sharma and three by Roy, and reads them through feminist theory, postcolonial feminist criticism, and feminist legal studies. The sections that follow lay out the theoretical framework, the authors and texts, the

existing scholarship, the research gap, the scope and objectives, the methodology, and the planned chapter structure of the thesis.

THEORETICAL OVERVIEW

The questions that this study asks cannot be answered by any single theoretical tradition. The home in modern Indian fiction is at once a site of gender performance, a site of caste and class inscription, and a site where law arrives in the form of statutes, courts, police, and lawyers. To read Sharma and Roy seriously, the study draws on three overlapping frameworks: feminist theory, postcolonial feminist criticism, and feminist legal studies. These are not used as separate boxes into which texts are sorted but as a connected set of tools that allow the reader to move between the intimate, the cultural, and the legal without losing sight of any of them.

The first framework is feminist theory, with Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990) as the foundational reference. Butler argues that gender is not an essence that a person carries inside them but a set of repeated acts and stylised behaviours that produce the impression of a stable identity. To be a "wife" or a "husband" in this view is not to express something innate but to perform a role that is recognised, rewarded, or punished within a given social field. This insight is useful for the fiction studied here because so much of what happens in Sharma's and Roy's novels turns on the policing of these performances inside the home. A wife who does not perform deference, a husband who does not perform mastery, a daughter who does not perform marriageability, all become objects of family and social discipline. Butler's account of how gender norms are sustained through repetition, and of how their authority can be punctured through failure, refusal, or parody, offers a way of reading the small disturbances inside marriage that fiction is especially good at capturing.

Butler's theory, however, was developed in a different cultural setting and cannot be applied without translation. Nivedita Menon's *Seeing Like a Feminist* (2012) provides the bridge. Menon argues that in India the family is not a private retreat from politics but the central institution through which patriarchy, caste, and property reproduce themselves. To take the family seriously as an object of feminist analysis is to denaturalise it, to see it as something built and maintained rather than something simply given. Menon is also useful for the way she handles law. She does not treat legal protection as the solution to women's subordination, nor does she dismiss it as a trap. Instead she insists that feminist work has to engage law on uneven and difficult terrain, because law shapes what is sayable and survivable inside the home. This double position, taking law seriously without idealising it, is close to the stance the present study tries to occupy.

The second framework is postcolonial feminist criticism, drawn primarily from the work of Rajeswari Sunder Rajan. Her *Real and Imagined Women* (1993) examines the gap between the women who actually live in Indian society and the women who are constructed in colonial and postcolonial discourse, in literature, in law, and in public debate. The figure of the "Indian woman" carries enormous symbolic weight. She stands for tradition, for the nation, for cultural authenticity, for victimhood requiring rescue. Sunder Rajan shows that this figure both shapes and obscures the lives of actual women. Her later book, *The Scandal of the State* (2003), turns more directly to the postcolonial state and asks how a polity that claims to protect women in fact governs them. She traces how law and welfare often work to discipline women even as they protect them. This framework is particularly important for reading Sharma's *498A: Fears and Dreams* and Roy's treatment of state power, because both writers are working in the space Sunder Rajan opens up, where protection and discipline are tangled together.

Postcolonial feminist criticism also brings caste into the analysis. Roy's fiction makes caste central, especially in *The God of Small Things*, where the love laws determine who can be touched and how. Sharma's fiction is less explicit on caste but assumes a particular middle class and largely upper caste milieu, which the study reads as a position rather than a neutral default. Postcolonial feminist thought insists that gender in India cannot be separated from caste, class, religion, and region, and the present study follows that insistence.

The third framework is feminist legal studies, with Srimati Basu's *The Trouble with Marriage* (2015) as the central source. Basu's ethnographic work inside family courts in India shows how the law on paper diverges from the law as it is lived. She follows what actually happens when a woman files a complaint under Section 498A or seeks divorce or maintenance, and her findings complicate both the celebratory and the dismissive accounts of these legal provisions. She finds that women's experience inside the court system is shaped by class, by access to lawyers and language, by the willingness of natal families to receive them back, and by the slow grinding pace of cases. Basu offers something that pure theory cannot, which is a sense of how legal protection feels from inside. Flavia Agnes's defence of Section 498A as a necessary protection, against the public discourse of misuse, supplies a second voice in this tradition. Together these scholars allow the study to read Sharma's *498A* not only as a literary text but as an intervention into an active legal and social debate.

Feminist legal studies is also where social reform enters the analysis. Patricia Uberoi's edited volume *Social Reform, Sexuality and the State* (1996) places contemporary debates about

marriage law in the long history of reform in India, from the nineteenth century onwards. This longer view matters because the question of what the state should do about marriage, dowry, and domestic violence is not new. Each generation reframes the question, and each legal reform carries the residue of earlier debates. Reading Sharma and Roy with Uberoi's collection in view keeps the study from treating the present moment as if it had no past.

These three frameworks are used together rather than separately. A scene of domestic conflict in Roy's *The God of Small Things* might call for Butler on gender performance, Sunder Rajan on the love laws and the construction of the Indian woman, and feminist legal studies on the way state machinery enters Ammu's life. A scene of legal procedure in Sharma's *498A: Fears and Dreams* might call primarily for Basu and Agnes, but it cannot be read responsibly without Menon's reminder that the family is not a private space and Butler's account of how performances of wifehood are policed in the household that surrounds the court case. The point is not to apply theory to fiction as a grid but to let theory and fiction question each other.

Two clarifications are in order. First, the study is grounded in feminist thought but does not treat feminism as a single, settled position. Indian feminism has internal disagreements about law, about reform, and about identity, and the study tries to keep these disagreements visible rather than smoothing them over. Second, the theoretical apparatus is used with a light hand. The chapters that follow are organised around the primary texts rather than around theorists, and theory enters where it does real reading work rather than as ornament.

OVERVIEW OF SELECTED TEXTS

This study works with two writers whose lives and careers have very little in common, except that both write in English and both keep returning to the same set of questions about marriage, family, and women's place in Indian society. Bringing them into the same room is part of what makes this project new. This section introduces them and the six books that the thesis will read most closely.

Dr. Vikas Sharma

Dr. Vikas Sharma is a professor of English and a novelist based in Meerut. He has spent his working life inside Indian universities, teaching English literature and writing fiction on the side. His novels are not bestsellers in the way Roy's are, and they are not reviewed in international magazines. They are read mostly in Indian English literature departments and in the journals that grow out of them. This setting matters. Sharma writes from the heart of the Indian middle class, from a town that is neither metropolitan Delhi nor village India, and his fiction carries the smell of that world. The drawing rooms, the kitchens, the family arguments, the careful talk about reputation, the constant calculations about marriage and money, all of this is the material his novels work with.

The first of his novels chosen for this study is *498A: Fears and Dreams*. The title points directly at Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code, the provision that allows a married woman to file a criminal complaint against her husband and his family for cruelty. The novel takes this law as its starting point and asks what happens inside a family when such a case is filed. Sharma is not writing a legal treatise. He is interested in how the law lives inside ordinary households, in the fear it produces on both sides, and in the way it changes the meaning of marriage itself. Earlier critics have read the book mostly as a comment on the misuse of the section, but the present study will argue that there is more going on inside it than that, and that reading it through feminist and legal theory opens up a richer picture.

The second is *Ashes and Fire*. This novel follows Suvidha, a young woman whose marriage does not go the way she expected, and traces what she does about it. The existing criticism on this novel has treated Suvidha as a strong female character and largely stopped there. What this study will do is push past the character reading to ask what the novel says about female agency,

about the limits of choice inside marriage, and about the social cost of stepping out of an expected role.

The third is *Love's Not Time's Fool*. The title borrows from Shakespeare, and the novel turns over the question of whether love survives the pressures of married life, time, money, and family. The book is the most reflective and the least directly legal of the three. Reading it alongside the other two will help the study show that Sharma's interest in marriage is not only an interest in court cases but in the slower, quieter ways in which marriages succeed and fail.

Arundhati Roy

Arundhati Roy needs less introduction. She won the Booker Prize in 1997 for her first novel and became one of the most recognised Indian writers in the world. She trained as an architect, worked as a screenwriter, and turned to fiction late by the standards of most novelists. After her first book she did not publish another novel for twenty years, and during that long gap she wrote a great deal of political non-fiction on subjects ranging from large dams to nuclear weapons to the wars inside India's own borders. Her work is read across the world and is also widely contested at home, where her political positions have made her both admired and disliked.

The first of her books chosen for this study is *The God of Small Things*, published in 1997. The novel is set in Kerala and follows a family across two generations. At its centre is Ammu, a divorced woman who returns to her parents' home with her twin children, and what happens when she falls in love with a man from a lower caste. The novel is famous for its style and for its treatment of caste, but for the purposes of this study it is the domestic and marital terrain that matters most. The family home in the novel is not a refuge. It is a place where caste, gender, and history collect.

The second is *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness*, published in 2017. The novel is sprawling. It moves between Old Delhi, Kashmir, and a graveyard that becomes a kind of community for those who do not fit anywhere else. It opens with Anjum, a hijra woman, and follows several other lives that touch hers. Recent criticism has read the novel mostly through the lens of transgender identity, state violence, and the Kashmir conflict, and these are clearly central concerns. The present study will read it for what it also is, a book about households, about who counts as family, and about the way love and care are organised when the conventional home fails.

The third is *My Seditious Heart*, published in 2019. This is a collection of Roy's political essays from across two decades. It is not fiction, but it sits in the same study because it lets the reader see what Roy is thinking about the state, about law, and about women's lives in arguments that her novels turn into stories. Reading the essays alongside the novels allows the study to show how her thinking about the home connects to her thinking about the country.

Placing Sharma's three books and Roy's three books on the same shelf produces a strange but useful pair. One writer works close in. One writer works wide. Both keep returning to the home. The chapters that follow will move between them.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Existing scholarship on the themes central to this study has grown steadily across Indian English literary criticism, feminist legal studies, and postcolonial feminist theory over the past three decades. A careful and systematic survey of the available literature, however, reveals three persistent gaps that the present thesis is positioned to address. The fiction of Dr Vikas Sharma has received only limited critical attention, and what attention exists remains theoretically underdeveloped, confined largely to plot summary, character psychology, and surface-level legal observation. Arundhati Roy, though extensively studied, has in recent years been read primarily through the lenses of transgender identity, ecological politics, and state violence, leaving the domestic and marital dimensions of her fiction comparatively neglected in current criticism. Most significantly, no published study has yet brought Sharma and Roy into the same comparative frame, nor has any work in Indian English literary studies combined feminist literary reading with feminist legal scholarship across the fiction of a male and a female contemporary Indian author writing about the same institutional space. The fifteen sources reviewed below are organised into three clusters. The first cluster examines scholarship directly concerned with Dr Vikas Sharma's fiction. The second addresses studies of Arundhati Roy's novels and essays. The third surveys the broader conversation on marriage, law, and feminist literary criticism that provides the methodological and theoretical context within which this thesis operates. Together, these sources define the state of the field and clarify the opening into which this research moves.

CLUSTER ONE: Scholarship on Dr Vikas Sharma

1. Garg, Poorvi. "Legal Safeguards or Legal Traps? Analysing Section 498A through Vikas Sharma's *498A: Fears and Dreams*." *The Creative Launcher*, vol. 10, no. 3, June 2025, pp. 56–60.

Poorvi Garg's article is the most legally focused piece of scholarship yet produced on Dr Vikas Sharma's fiction, and it occupies an important position in this review because it engages directly with the same legal provision that organises a significant portion of the present thesis. Writing in *The Creative Launcher* in 2025, Garg reads *498A: Fears and Dreams* as an extended work of social commentary on Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code, tracing how the novel

dramatises the fear, confusion, and domestic disruption that follow when a criminal complaint is filed under this provision. Her reading is attentive to legal detail, and she navigates the public debate around the section with some care, acknowledging both its protective intent and the anxieties about misuse that Sharma's novel foregrounds. These are genuine contributions, and the article is a useful entry point into the critical conversation around Sharma's most explicitly legal novel. However, the limitations of Garg's approach are considerable from the perspective of the present study. Her analysis does not engage with feminist theory at any level. The women characters in *498A: Fears and Dreams* are treated primarily as participants in a legal and social debate rather than as subjects whose experience of marriage, cruelty, and law is shaped by structures of gender, caste, and class that exceed the immediate courtroom drama. There is no engagement with the work of scholars such as Srimati Basu or Flavia Agnes, whose feminist legal scholarship would have opened the novel's treatment of Section 498A to a far more searching analysis. The result is a reading that is informative about the novel's legal surface but does not penetrate the deeper questions about what the law does to women inside the household, how it shapes intimacy and fear in equal measure, and what it reveals about the distance between legal reform on paper and the texture of married life in practice. The present thesis takes Garg's article as a starting point precisely because it demonstrates both the possibility and the limits of reading Sharma through a legal lens without feminist theoretical grounding. Where Garg stops, this study begins.

2. Sharma, Krishna Kumar. "Psychological Projections in Vikas Sharma's Novel *498A: Fears and Dreams*." ResearchGate, Feb. 2024.

Krishna Kumar Sharma's article approaches *498A: Fears and Dreams* from a psychological rather than a legal or feminist direction, and in doing so it represents a second dominant tendency in Sharma criticism, namely the tendency to read the novels inward toward character psychology while leaving the structural and institutional conditions that produce those psychological states largely unexamined. The article traces mechanisms of psychological projection in the novel's principal characters, attending to the inner conflicts, emotional displacements, and defensive manoeuvres that marriage, suspicion, and legal crisis produce in the people Sharma writes about. There is genuine sensitivity here to the emotional register of the fiction, and the article succeeds in showing that *498A: Fears and Dreams* is not merely a legal tract but a novel genuinely interested in the interior lives of its characters under pressure.

This is a useful corrective to readings that reduce the novel entirely to its social commentary function. Nevertheless, the psychological framework operates in isolation from any wider theoretical apparatus. The feelings and conflicts the article traces are read as individual psychological events rather than as the products of gendered power relations inside the household, of patriarchal structures that assign particular roles and punish departures from them, or of a legal system that enters the most intimate spaces of domestic life and reorganises them. Judith Butler's account of how gender norms are sustained through repetition and enforced through punishment would have given the psychological observations a structural home. Nivedita Menon's insistence that the family is not a private space but a political one would have reframed what it means for these characters to experience what they experience inside their marriages. The absence of such frameworks does not invalidate the article's observations but it does leave them floating free of the conditions that produce them. The present thesis draws on Krishna Kumar Sharma's sensitivity to the emotional interior of Sharma's fiction while insisting that those emotional realities are inseparable from the feminist and legal structures that this study foregrounds throughout its comparative analysis.

3. Awasthi, Pragya. "Ashes and Fire: Newly Emerging Notion of a Female Protagonist." *Notions*, vol. 13, June 2021.

Pragya Awasthi's article in *Notions* is the only sustained critical reading of *Ashes and Fire* available in the published scholarship, and its importance to this review lies partly in what it achieves and partly in the considerable analytical territory it leaves open. Awasthi identifies Suvidha, the novel's central female character, as a new kind of protagonist in Indian English fiction, a woman who is simultaneously traditional and modern, dependent and self-determining, and who navigates the competing demands placed on her by family, desire, widowhood, and social expectation with a complexity that resists easy categorisation. This is a perceptive starting observation. Suvidha is indeed a more contradictory and interesting figure than the either-or categories of Indian feminist fiction typically allow, and Awasthi is right to flag her as something worth paying sustained critical attention to. The difficulty is that the article stops almost as soon as it has made this identification. Suvidha is named as a strong female protagonist, her contradictions are noted, and the essay moves on without asking the harder structural questions that such a character demands. What are the material and social conditions that produce a woman like Suvidha? What does the novel say about the limits of

female agency inside marriage and widowhood in contemporary middle-class Indian society? What does it cost Suvidha to step outside the script assigned to her, and what languages does the novel find to speak about that cost? These questions remain entirely unasked, and the feminist theoretical frameworks that would allow them to be pursued rigorously are entirely absent from Awasthi's analysis. The present thesis treats Awasthi's article as an important but incomplete first word on *Ashes and Fire*, one that correctly identifies the novel's central character as analytically significant but does not begin to exhaust what a theoretically informed feminist reading of that character and her domestic circumstances can reveal. Chapters Four and Eight of this thesis take the reading of Suvidha substantially further, placing her within the frameworks of gender performance, female agency, and social reform that Awasthi's article gestures toward but does not enter.

4. Sharma, Vandana, editor. *Critiquing the Novels of Vikas Sharma*. Diamond Pocket Books, 2022.

Vandana Sharma's edited volume is the first and, at the time of writing, the only critical book devoted entirely to Dr Vikas Sharma's fiction, and its publication in 2022 marks a significant moment in the emergence of Sharma as a subject of sustained academic attention. The volume brings together multiple critical essays on Sharma's novels, including Sharma, Preksha's chapter "Shifting and Non-Equalising Gender: A Reading of Vikas Sharma's *498A: Fears and Dreams*," Singh, Kanwar Pal's chapter on *Love's Not Time's Fool* as a representative novel of the twenty-first century, and Devi, Anshu's examination of language and style in *498A: Fears and Dreams*. The range of topics covered and the number of contributors gathered in a single volume testify to the growing recognition of Sharma's fiction as a legitimate object of literary study. Several chapters are genuinely useful as introductory maps of the novels' themes, characters, and social concerns, and the volume as a whole provides an indispensable foundation for any scholar working on Sharma. However, the collection as a whole does not move beyond this introductory function. The chapters are overwhelmingly descriptive in orientation, offering plot summaries, character sketches, and thematic overviews without bringing any of the major frameworks of feminist theory, postcolonial feminist criticism, or feminist legal studies to bear on the texts they discuss. The chapter on gender in *498A: Fears and Dreams* identifies the gendered dynamics of the novel as a concern but does not theorise them. The chapters on *Love's Not Time's Fool* treat it as a novel about love and modernity

without asking what it says about the institution of marriage as a site of power, constraint, and negotiation. The volume is, in short, a necessary but theoretically insufficient body of scholarship. The present thesis engages with it throughout as a point of departure, taking the descriptive groundwork it provides and building on it the kind of theoretically rigorous, comparatively structured feminist analysis that the volume does not attempt.

5. Singh, Nisha, editor. *The Concept of Womanhood in the Novels of Vikas Sharma*. The Women Press, 2024.

Nisha Singh's edited volume represents the most gender-focused critical work yet produced on Dr Vikas Sharma's fiction, and its publication in 2024 signals that the question of how Sharma writes women is now being taken seriously as a sustained scholarly concern rather than a passing observation. Singh herself is an academic with a research background in ecofeminism and women's empowerment, and the volume she has edited brings that orientation to bear on Sharma's novels across a range of essays that examine womanhood as a thematic, representational, and social category in his fiction. The volume covers Sharma's treatment of female characters across multiple novels, tracing patterns of independence, desire, constraint, and social expectation that run through his work as a whole. This is a significant contribution to the field, and the present thesis acknowledges it as the closest existing study to its own concerns. The limitations, however, are real and are worth stating precisely because they define exactly where this thesis's contribution begins. Singh's volume treats womanhood primarily as a thematic category. It asks what kinds of women Sharma writes and what those women want, but it does not ask what produces and constrains those women at the level of social structure, legal provision, and historical formation. Feminist theory in the sense of Butler on gender performance, Menon on the family as a political institution, or Sunder Rajan on the postcolonial state's ambivalent relationship with women's lives does not enter the analysis in any systematic way. Feminist legal studies, which would allow the volume to connect Sharma's women characters to the actual workings of Section 498A, maintenance law, and the family court system, is entirely absent. The result is a volume that maps the surface of Sharma's gender concerns richly but does not penetrate to the structural and institutional conditions that give those concerns their full significance. The present thesis builds directly on Singh's volume while moving it into theoretical territory it does not occupy.

6. Sachdeva, Ashok. *Novels of Vikas Sharma: A Critical Appraisal*. Authors Press, 2024.

Ashok Sachdeva's critical appraisal of Sharma's novels, published in 2024 and already being cited in the most recent journal scholarship on the author, is a further marker of the growing momentum of Sharma criticism as a field. The appearance of a second book-length study of Sharma's fiction within two years of the first, the Vandana Sharma edited volume of 2022, indicates that the critical conversation around this author is expanding with some speed, and the present thesis situates itself within that expanding conversation while distinguishing its contribution from what Sachdeva's appraisal offers. A full-length critical appraisal of Sharma's novels provides something that individual journal articles cannot, namely a sustained overview of the author's development as a novelist, the range and consistency of his thematic concerns, and the place his fiction occupies within contemporary Indian English literary production. Sachdeva's volume performs this function and does so across Sharma's wider novelistic output rather than focusing on a single text. This breadth is both a strength and a limitation. Because the appraisal covers the full range of Sharma's novels, it necessarily treats each individual text with less depth than a focused comparative study of three primary texts can achieve. More significantly, a general critical appraisal is not organised around a theoretical argument of the kind that drives the present thesis. The question this study asks, namely what the Indian home means as a site of marital conflict, gendered injury, and legal intervention when Sharma's fiction is read through feminist and postcolonial feminist frameworks, is not the question a critical appraisal sets out to answer. Sachdeva's volume is therefore acknowledged here as an important contribution to the growing body of Sharma scholarship while the present thesis claims a different and more theoretically specific kind of engagement with the primary texts.

7. Najar, Sarwar Ahmad. "Beyond Feminism: A Study of Prof. Vikas Sharma's *498A: Fears and Dreams*." *The Criterion: An International Journal in English*, vol. 14, no. 1, Feb. 2023, ISSN: 0976-8165.

Sarwar Ahmad Najar's article occupies a unique position in this literature review because its title announces a critical position that the present thesis directly contests. To read *498A: Fears and Dreams* as a novel that goes beyond feminism, as Najar proposes, is to treat feminist frameworks as something the fiction has already absorbed and moved past, something that can be acknowledged and set aside in favour of a wider or more inclusive reading. The present

thesis argues the opposite: that feminist theory, postcolonial feminist criticism, and feminist legal studies are not frameworks that Sharma's fiction has exhausted but frameworks through which it has never yet been seriously read, and that applying them produces a richer, more analytically accountable account of what the novel does with marriage, law, and female experience than any post-feminist or extra-feminist reading can achieve. Najar's article is therefore valuable not as a model to follow but as a position to engage with critically. It represents a tendency in Indian literary criticism to treat feminist reading as one option among many, to be adopted or set aside according to the critic's preference, rather than as a rigorous methodological commitment that transforms what can be seen in a text. The article also illuminates a broader pattern in Sharma criticism: the willingness to note gender as a theme without subjecting it to theoretical scrutiny. Najar observes that the novel raises questions about women's lives and legal rights but does not pursue those questions through the feminist frameworks that would give them analytical depth. Reading this article alongside Garg's 2025 piece and Krishna Kumar Sharma's psychological study, one sees a consistent pattern: Sharma criticism acknowledges gender and law as concerns without theorising either. The present thesis identifies this pattern as the central gap in existing scholarship and makes the theorisation of gender and law its organising commitment.

8. Sharma, Krishna Kumar. "Manifestation of Pro-Feminism in Vikas Sharma's Novel *Ashes and Fire*." *Cognitive Thinking: An International Journal of Interdisciplinary Studies*, vol. 1, no. 2, Apr.–June 2025.

This article, the most recently published piece of scholarship on Dr Vikas Sharma's fiction at the time of writing, is significant for two reasons. First, it makes the most explicit attempt yet in Sharma criticism to theorise the author's relationship to feminism, positioning Sharma as a pro-feminist writer whose fiction draws on the tradition of male feminism associated with scholars such as Raewyn Connell and Robert Jensen. Second, it introduces ecofeminism into the reading of *Ashes and Fire* through the novel's treatment of the Hindon river and the environmental degradation of the Ghaziabad landscape in which Suvidha's story unfolds. Both of these moves represent genuine advances on the existing scholarship. The attempt to theorise Sharma's feminist commitments rather than simply noting them is welcome, and the ecofeminist reading of *Ashes and Fire* opens a dimension of the novel that no previous critic had addressed. However, the article's theoretical reach does not extend to the questions that

matter most for the present thesis. The pro-feminist and ecofeminist frameworks it deploys do not connect Suvidha's experience to the legal architecture of marriage and domestic life in contemporary India. The domestic interior of the novel, the household as a space where gender norms are enforced, where legal provisions shape the possibilities available to women, and where the slow work of social reform is tested against the grain of everyday life, remains outside the article's analytical frame. The ecofeminist reading, while productive on its own terms, does not address the marital and legal dimensions of Suvidha's situation that the present thesis places at the centre of its reading of *Ashes and Fire*. This article is therefore acknowledged as the most theoretically ambitious piece of Sharma criticism yet published while the present study takes the theorisation of Sharma's gender politics into territory the article does not enter.

CLUSTER TWO: Scholarship on Arundhati Roy

9. Yadav, Sharda Singh Gaur, and Uma Shankar. "Exploring Women's Place and Subjectivity Formation in the Novels of Arundhati Roy: A Comparative Analysis of *The God of Small Things* and *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness*." *Journal of Advances and Scholarly Researches in Allied Education*, vol. 20, no. 4, Oct. 2023, pp. 49–61.

Yadav and Shankar's comparative article is one of the few pieces of recent Roy scholarship that reads both primary novels this thesis engages, and it does so through a feminist and intersectional lens that makes it a methodologically useful reference point. The article examines how women's subjectivity is formed and constrained across the two novels, tracing the pressures of caste, class, gender, and familial expectation that shape the interior lives of Roy's female characters. The authors are attentive to the way Roy's fiction refuses to present womanhood as a stable or unified category, showing instead how different women in different social positions experience the same patriarchal structures with different intensities and different consequences. This attention to intersectionality is genuinely productive, and the article succeeds in demonstrating that a comparative feminist reading of Roy's two major novels is both possible and analytically rewarding. However, from the perspective of the present thesis, the article's limitation is significant. Its focus is on women's interior subject formation, on how women come to understand themselves and their desires within the conditions Roy's fiction creates, rather than on the domestic and legal architecture that produces

and constrains that subjectivity from the outside. The household as a structure of power, the law as a force that enters the bedroom and the kitchen, the institution of marriage as a site where gendered injury is inflicted and survived, these dimensions of Roy's fiction do not receive sustained attention in Yadav and Shankar's reading. The article reads inward toward the female subject while the present thesis reads outward toward the institutional and legal conditions that shape her. This difference in orientation is not a criticism of Yadav and Shankar's work on its own terms but it does clarify why, despite the methodological overlap, their article leaves open the specific reading of Roy's domestic and marital terrain that this thesis undertakes.

10. Rashmi, G. H. "The Evolution of Feminist Perspectives in Indian English Literature: An Analysis of Arundhati Roy's *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness*." *IRE Journals*, vol. 8, no. 3, 2024, pp. 835–847.

Rashmi's article is representative of the most energetic current tendency in Roy scholarship, the reading of *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* through the figure of Anjum as a transgender subject whose life and choices constitute a form of subaltern resistance to the normative structures of gender, family, and state power. The article traces how Anjum's identity and her decision to make her home in a graveyard outside the boundaries of conventional domestic space constitute a feminist and political act, a refusal of the home as it is normally constituted and an assertion of the possibility of alternative forms of community and belonging. Rashmi brings theoretical alertness to this reading, drawing on frameworks of gender fluidity and subaltern resistance that are well suited to illuminating what Roy is doing with Anjum's character and the social world she inhabits. The reading is persuasive within its chosen frame, and the article makes a genuine contribution to the understanding of *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* as a novel concerned with the bodies and lives that conventional domestic and social arrangements exclude. The limitation for the purposes of the present thesis is that the focus on Anjum as a transgender figure, while intellectually productive, necessarily pushes to the margins the novel's treatment of heterosexual marriage, the conventional household, and the legal and social mechanisms through which ordinary married women negotiate domestic life in contemporary India. *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* is not only a novel about those who fall outside the domestic norm. It is also a novel about the households that produce and enforce that norm, about the broken marriages and the domestic failures that send characters like Tilo

into alternative modes of living. Rashmi's article illuminates one dimension of the novel with considerable skill while the present thesis attends to the domestic and marital dimensions that this line of reading tends to pass over. Both readings are necessary, and the present thesis situates itself in relation to the Anjum-centred criticism by arguing that the household and the law remain central to *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* even for readers whose primary interest lies elsewhere.

11. Prasad, Poonam, and Ranga R. "The Politics of Representing Gender and Sexuality in Arundhati Roy's Selected Books." *World Journal of English Language*, vol. 16, no. 1, 2026, p. 305.

Prasad and Ranga's article takes a wide-angle view of Roy's treatment of gender and sexuality across both her fiction and her political essays, moving through intersectionality, representations of LGBTQ+ identity, and the relationship between the state's exercise of power and the bodies of those it governs. The article is ambitious in its scope and brings several of Roy's most important concerns into a single analytical frame, showing how her thinking about gender is inseparable from her thinking about nationalism, militarism, caste, and the postcolonial state. This breadth is the article's strength. It demonstrates that Roy's engagement with gender is not confined to the domestic interior but radiates outward into every dimension of public and political life, which is part of what makes her such a rich subject for the kind of feminist reading the present thesis undertakes. The limitation, again from the specific perspective of this study, is that the outward radiation of Roy's gender politics comes at the cost of attention to the household itself. The article treats the state in considerable detail but does not focus on marriage as an institution or on the domestic interior as a space where larger political forces are felt in intimate and everyday ways. The home appears in the article primarily as one site among many where state power operates rather than as the central analytical object that the present thesis makes it. Prasad and Ranga's work is valuable for confirming that Roy's political essays and her fiction are best read together as a single body of thinking about power, gender, and justice, which is one reason this thesis includes *My Seditious Heart* alongside the two novels in its primary corpus. However, the domestic and marital reading of Roy that the present thesis undertakes remains outside the frame of their analysis, and the gap their article leaves is part of what this study moves into.

12. Shukla, Minakshi, and Upasana Bharati. "Intersections of Postcolonialism, Eco-Criticism, and Feminism in Arundhati Roy's Novels: A Comprehensive Literature Review." *International Journal of Multidisciplinary Research in Arts, Science and Technology*, vol. 3, no. 3, Mar. 2025, pp. 31–45.

Shukla and Bharati's comprehensive literature review performs a function that is unusually useful for the present thesis: it maps the current state of Roy scholarship with enough systematic thoroughness to make the shape of the field visible as a whole rather than piece by piece. The article surveys the major critical traditions that have grown up around Roy's fiction, identifying postcolonialism, ecofeminism, and feminist readings of identity and resistance as the dominant modes of engagement in recent years. It traces how each of these critical traditions has developed in relation to Roy's two novels and her non-fiction, noting which aspects of the work each tradition has illuminated and, more implicitly, which aspects it has left in the shade. What the article reveals, perhaps more clearly than any single critical essay could, is that the domestic and marital terrain of Roy's fiction is not currently among the priorities of the field. The critical energy that Shukla and Bharati map is directed toward the ecological, the postcolonial, the transgender, and the politically public rather than toward the household, marriage, and the law as they bear on ordinary women's lives inside the home. This is precisely the observation on which the present thesis bases part of its claim to originality. The literature review by Shukla and Bharati does not argue that the domestic and marital reading of Roy is unnecessary or exhausted. It simply confirms, by surveying the field comprehensively, that such a reading has not yet been undertaken with the sustained theoretical rigour that the fiction demands. The present thesis takes this confirmation as a mandate and proceeds accordingly, placing Roy's treatment of the household, marriage, caste, and law at the centre of its reading rather than at the periphery.

CLUSTER THREE: Marriage, Law, and Feminist Literary Criticism

13. Basu, Srimati. *The Trouble with Marriage: Feminists Confront Law and Violence in India*. University of California Press, 2015.

Srimati Basu's ethnographic study of feminist engagements with marriage law and domestic violence in India is the single most important work of feminist legal scholarship informing the

present thesis, and its contribution to the study cannot be overstated. Basu spent years inside Indian family courts, following what actually happens when women file complaints under Section 498A, seek maintenance, or pursue divorce, and her findings are indispensable for any literary study that wishes to connect the representation of law in fiction to the reality of law as it is lived. What Basu shows, with the granular detail that only sustained ethnographic work can produce, is that the law on paper and the law in practice are separated by a vast and consequential distance. Women's experience inside the court system is shaped not only by the text of the statute but by their class position, their access to legal language and competent representation, their natal family's willingness to receive them back, and the slow and exhausting pace of cases that can drag on for years while the household and the marriage continue to exist in a state of suspended crisis. This picture of how legal protection actually feels from inside is something that pure theoretical work cannot supply, and it gives the present thesis a ground-level reference point against which to read both Sharma's fictional account of Section 498A in action and Roy's wider treatment of the postcolonial state's ambivalent relationship with women's lives. Basu also models the intellectual position that the present thesis tries to occupy: taking law seriously without idealising it, acknowledging its protective possibilities without ignoring the ways in which the legal process can discipline and further constrain the very women it claims to protect. This double position, sceptical but not dismissive, engaged but not credulous, is essential to the kind of feminist legal reading that Chapters Seven and Eight of this thesis carry out.

14. Agnes, Flavia. "Is Domestic Violence a Lesser Crime? Countering the Backlash against Section 498A, IPC." ResearchGate, 2016.

Flavia Agnes's article is a polemical and scholarly defence of Section 498A against the tide of public and judicial opinion that, particularly from the mid-2000s onward, began to characterise the provision primarily as a tool of misuse rather than as a protection for women in violent marriages. Agnes writes from a position of long experience in women's legal rights activism and feminist legal advocacy, and her argument is grounded in the lived realities of women who have used the section to seek protection rather than in the abstract debates about legal principle that dominate the backlash discourse she contests. She documents how the narrative of misuse, amplified by media coverage and certain judicial pronouncements, has functioned to delegitimise women's complaints and to shift the burden of proof, in public perception if not

always in legal procedure, from the accused to the complainant. Her argument is that domestic violence is not a lesser crime than other forms of violence but has been systematically treated as one by a legal culture that continues to privilege the sanctity of the marriage over the safety of the woman inside it. This argument is directly relevant to the present thesis on two counts. First, it provides the legal and sociological counterweight to the misuse-centred reading of Section 498A that dominates the critical conversation around Sharma's *498A: Fears and Dreams*. The existing scholarship on that novel, as the review of Garg and Najar above makes clear, tends to read Sharma's treatment of the section primarily through the lens of misuse and male suffering. Agnes's work insists that this lens, however dramatically compelling, is not the only or even the primary way to understand what Section 498A does and why it exists. Second, Agnes's article exemplifies a mode of feminist legal argument that treats law as contested terrain, shaped by power relations that extend well beyond the courtroom, which is the mode of legal analysis this thesis brings to its reading of both Sharma and Roy.

15. Menon, Nivedita. *Seeing Like a Feminist*. Zubaan and Penguin Books India, 2012.

Nivedita Menon's *Seeing Like a Feminist* is the theoretical work that most directly bridges the gap between the Western feminist theory on which this thesis draws, particularly Judith Butler's account of gender performativity, and the specific social, legal, and political conditions of Indian patriarchy within which both Sharma and Roy write. Menon's book is not a work of literary criticism. It is a sustained and wide-ranging argument about what it means to see the world through a feminist lens in the Indian context, covering the family, the law, sexuality, work, and the body as sites where feminist analysis must operate simultaneously rather than in sequence. The book's central argument, that the family in India is not a private retreat from politics but the central institution through which patriarchy, caste, and property reproduce themselves across generations, is the foundational premise of the present thesis. To call the Indian home a battleground, as this study's title does, is to make a claim that Menon's work theorises with a thoroughness and a contextual precision that no Western feminist text can match. Menon is also particularly useful for the way she handles the relationship between feminism and law in the Indian context. She does not treat legal reform as the solution to women's subordination, which would be a naive position given the history of Indian legislation on marriage and family, nor does she dismiss law as a trap or a tool of further oppression, which would be an equally inadequate response to the genuine protections that provisions like

Section 498A have offered to women in violent households. Instead she occupies the difficult middle ground, insisting that feminist engagement with law must be sustained precisely because law shapes what is sayable and survivable inside the home, even when that engagement is uncomfortable and the outcomes are uneven. This is the intellectual position the present thesis attempts to inhabit throughout its comparative reading of Sharma and Roy, and Menon's work is the most important single theoretical resource that makes that position available.

Taken together, these fifteen sources define both the state of the existing field and the opening into which the present thesis moves. The Sharma scholarship, as the first cluster demonstrates, has produced useful descriptive and introductory work but has not yet subjected the fiction to sustained feminist or legal theoretical analysis. The Roy scholarship, as the second cluster shows, is rich and theoretically sophisticated but has in recent years directed its energy away from the domestic and marital terrain that remains central to Roy's fiction. The third cluster provides the feminist legal and theoretical frameworks that the present thesis brings to both authors. No published study has yet combined these three bodies of work in the way this thesis proposes, and it is the combination, the reading of Sharma and Roy together through feminist theory, postcolonial feminist criticism, and feminist legal studies, that constitutes the original contribution this research makes to the field of Indian English literary studies.

RESEARCH GAP

The literature review has shown that the field has serious openings. The present section names these openings directly and explains why this thesis is positioned to address them.

The first and most basic gap is the simplest to state. No published study has read Dr Vikas Sharma and Arundhati Roy together. Across the fifteen sources examined, and across the broader bibliographies they point to, the two writers have not been placed in the same frame. This is unusual, because their concerns overlap in ways that should already have produced comparative work. Both write about marriage as a site of conflict. Both write about how the home contains and constrains women. Both write about law, though from different angles and with different levels of explicit attention. The absence of any prior comparison is therefore not because the comparison would be far-fetched. It is because Indian English literary criticism has tended to keep its bestselling and academically respected authors in one set and its less internationally known academic novelists in another, and the two sets are rarely brought together. This study refuses that separation.

The second gap concerns the theoretical poverty of the Sharma scholarship and the thematic drift of the Roy scholarship. The criticism on Dr Sharma, as the literature review showed, has stayed close to plot, character, and surface legal commentary. It has not been read through feminist theory, postcolonial feminist criticism, or feminist legal studies in any sustained way. The Roy criticism has the opposite problem. It is theoretically rich, but its recent attention has moved towards transgender identity, ecology, and state violence, and the question of marriage, the household, and the law as they bear on ordinary married women has been pushed to the side. This study reads Dr Sharma with the theoretical seriousness his fiction deserves, and it brings the household and marriage in Roy back into focus without abandoning the wider concerns recent critics have brought out.

The third gap concerns the structure of comparative feminist work in Indian fiction. The closest methodological precedents, the *Veterinaria* article on Deshpande and Kapur, the *Creative Flight Journal* piece on Das, Deshpande, and Desai, and the work on Manju Kapur, all read women writers in relation to other women writers. The comparative move across the gender of the author has not been made. This is a real absence. A male writer's view of marriage is not the same as a female writer's view, and the comparison is worth making precisely because the two positions sit differently inside the institution. By placing a male author and a female author

on the same shelf and reading both through feminist frameworks, this study tests whether the existing critical habit of reading women writers and male writers in separate rooms can be productively broken.

The fourth gap concerns method. Literary criticism on Indian fiction has rarely combined feminist literary reading with feminist legal studies. The Agnes article and the Basu book sit in a different disciplinary world from the literary articles surveyed above. This study brings the two worlds together. It reads novels with the help of legal ethnography and reads legal ethnography with the help of novels.

The opening into which this thesis steps is therefore not a small one. It is a missing comparison, a missing theoretical engagement, a missing cross-gender reading, and a missing methodological combination. Closing these gaps is the contribution this study aims to make.

RESEARCH PROBLEM

The Indian home has been a recurring site in literary and scholarly imagination, yet the critical conversation has rarely treated the domestic interior as the primary zone of conflict, a space where gender, law, and social reform collide in everyday life. This study is animated by a specific and underexamined problem: the persistent gap between what legal reform promises women inside marriage and what the institution actually delivers to them in practice.

Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code was designed to protect women from cruelty within the household, yet public discourse has increasingly framed it as a tool of misuse rather than a shield of protection. The fiction that engages most directly with this terrain, including the novels of Dr Vikas Sharma, has not been read through the feminist and legal theoretical frameworks that would allow its full significance to become visible. On the other side of the comparison, Arundhati Roy's domestic and marital terrain has been progressively marginalised in recent criticism in favour of transgender identity, ecological politics, and state violence, even though the household remains central to her fiction.

The problem this study addresses is therefore double. A body of fiction that engages directly with marriage, domestic cruelty, and legal intervention has not been read through the frameworks it demands, and a widely studied author whose domestic terrain is analytically rich has had that terrain pushed to the side. No published work has brought these two writers together, and no study in Indian English literary criticism has combined feminist literary reading with feminist legal scholarship across the fiction of a male and a female contemporary author writing about the same institutional space. The present thesis identifies this double absence as the problem it is positioned to solve.

RATIONALE OF THE STUDY

The reasons for undertaking this study are both scholarly and social.

The scholarly rationale begins with the state of the field. Sharma criticism has remained largely descriptive, without sustained feminist or legal theoretical engagement. Roy criticism, though theoretically rich, has drifted away from the domestic interior her fiction keeps returning to. The comparative move of placing a male and a female contemporary Indian author in the same analytical frame has not been made in Indian English literary studies. Each of these absences would justify a new study; taken together they define the gap this thesis enters.

The methodological rationale is equally strong. Literary criticism on Indian fiction and feminist legal scholarship have largely operated in separate disciplinary spaces. Scholars such as Srimati Basu and Flavia Agnes have produced grounded accounts of how marriage law works in practice, but their work has not been brought into dialogue with the novels that fictionalise the same terrain. This study argues that the two disciplines need each other, and the integration of feminist legal scholarship with close literary reading is one of its original contributions.

The social rationale cannot be separated from the scholarly one. The debate around Section 498A continues to have real consequences for real households. The question of whether the Indian home is a safe space or a site of structured inequality is not settled, and literature is one of the places where a society thinks through its most difficult questions. Finally, the timing is right. Sharma scholarship is young and growing rapidly, and the theoretical and comparative work needs to happen before the critical conversation settles into habits that will be harder to displace.

RESEARCH OBJECTIVES

The study sets out to do six things. Each objective follows from the research gap identified above and contributes to the overall argument that the Indian home in modern fiction can be read as a battleground.

1. To examine how the home is constructed and contested in the fiction of Dr Vikas Sharma and Arundhati Roy as a site of marital conflict, gendered injury, and legal intervention.
2. To analyse the representation of marriage, dowry harassment, and domestic violence in Dr Sharma's three novels, with particular attention to how the law enters the household in *498A: Fears and Dreams* and how female agency is negotiated in *Ashes and Fire* and *Love's Not Time's Fool*.
3. To analyse Roy's three texts for their treatment of marriage, the household, caste, and state power as they bear on women's lives, with particular attention to *The God of Small Things* and to the household scenes in *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness*, supplemented by *My Seditious Heart* on questions of law and reform.
4. To bring the two authors into a sustained comparative frame, asking what reading them together reveals about gender, law, and the Indian home that neither writer shows alone.
5. To read both writers through feminist theory, postcolonial feminist criticism, and feminist legal studies, and to demonstrate the value of an integrated theoretical approach over the single framework readings that dominate the existing scholarship.
6. To contribute to Indian English literary criticism a model for comparing male and female contemporary writers on shared questions of marriage, gender justice, and social reform, and for combining literary reading with feminist legal scholarship.

Taken together, these six objectives map the route the thesis travels, from its opening question about the Indian home as a site of conflict to its final contribution to the field of Indian English literary studies.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

1. How do the selected novels of Dr Vikas Sharma and Arundhati Roy represent the Indian home as a site of marital conflict, and what does this shared preoccupation reveal when both writers are read together?
2. In what ways does Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code shape the lives of women characters in Sharma's fiction, and how does Roy's treatment of law and institutional power in her novels and essays extend or challenge that picture?
3. How is female agency negotiated within the domestic space in the six primary texts, and what factors, whether legal, social, or caste-based, determine its possibilities and limits?
4. What does the comparison between Sharma's close, interior view of marriage and Roy's wider, politically inflected view reveal about the gap between legal reform and lived experience in contemporary India?
5. How does the Indian home function differently as a narrative space in the work of a male author and a female author writing about the same institution, and what does that difference tell us about gender, perspective, and literary form?

EXPECTED OUTCOME

The thesis expects to produce four interconnected contributions.

The first is a sustained feminist and legal reading of Dr Vikas Sharma's three primary novels, which does not currently exist in the published scholarship. This will establish a new critical baseline for all future work on his fiction.

The second is a reorientation of Roy criticism toward the domestic and marital terrain that recent scholarship has moved away from. The thesis will demonstrate that this reading deepens rather than competes with the existing work on caste, state violence, and gender identity in her fiction.

The third is the comparative framework itself. By reading a male and a female contemporary Indian author together on shared questions of marriage, gender justice, and social reform, the thesis offers a replicable model for future comparative work in Indian English literary criticism, a field that has tended to keep its male and female authors in separate critical conversations.

The fourth is methodological. The integration of Basu's ethnographic work, Agnes's legal arguments, and Menon's theoretical account of the family with close literary reading will produce a model of interdisciplinary feminist criticism that scholars working at the intersection of law and literature in the Indian context can adapt and extend.

Taken together, these outcomes amount to a contribution that is comparative in design, feminist in theoretical orientation, interdisciplinary in method, and grounded throughout in close reading of the primary texts. The thesis does not claim to settle the questions it raises. It claims to open them more rigorously than they have been opened before

SCOPE

This section sets out clearly what the study will cover and what it will leave to the side. A synopsis of this length cannot do everything, and the value of the project depends as much on disciplined limits as on its ambitions.

The primary scope is six books. Three are by Dr Vikas Sharma: *498A: Fears and Dreams*, *Ashes and Fire*, and *Love's Not Time's Fool*. Three are by Arundhati Roy: *The God of Small Things*, *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness*, and *My Seditious Heart*. These six texts are read closely throughout the thesis. Other works by both authors are referred to where they illuminate a specific point, but they are not given sustained chapter length treatment. This choice keeps the close reading deep rather than thin.

The theoretical scope is set by three traditions: feminist theory, postcolonial feminist criticism, and feminist legal studies. Within these the study works most closely with Butler, Menon, Sunder Rajan, Basu, Agnes, and Uberoi. Other feminist traditions, such as psychoanalytic feminism, Marxist feminism, and ecofeminism, are acknowledged in the literature review but are not used as primary lenses. The reason is straightforward. The texts ask questions about gender, the state, and law together, and the three chosen frameworks are best equipped to answer those questions in combination.

The geographical and linguistic scope is Indian English fiction of the post liberalisation period. The study does not engage with regional language literature in any sustained way, although it acknowledges that important work on marriage and women's lives has been written in Hindi, Malayalam, Bengali, Tamil, and other Indian languages. The choice of English language fiction is dictated by the corpus and by the language in which both authors write.

The disciplinary scope is literary. The thesis reads law and ethnography as context and as theory, but it does not attempt original legal scholarship. It does not analyse case law, judgments, or court statistics on its own terms. Where legal material enters, it does so through the existing work of legal scholars such as Agnes and Basu. The study also does not engage with film adaptations, theatre, journalism beyond Roy's own essays, or any other medium. Its object is the novel and the political essay.

Finally, the thematic scope is the home as battleground, with marital conflict, gender justice, and social reform as the three threads pulled through it. Other important themes in Roy's work,

such as the Kashmir conflict, the ecological politics of dams and forests, and the long history of caste, are recognised but are not central. They enter the thesis only where they touch the domestic and marital questions that organise the study. The same discipline applies to Dr Sharma's wider concerns with academic life and middle class aspiration, which appear only where they bear on the domestic argument.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

The thesis uses methods that are appropriate to a literary study with a strong interest in gender, law, and social context. This section explains how the work will be carried out. The aim is to keep the methods clear and honest, not to dress them up in technical language.

The primary method is close reading. Close reading means going through the chosen texts slowly, with attention to language, narrative structure, character, imagery, and the small details that often carry the heaviest meaning. In the case of Dr Vikas Sharma and Arundhati Roy, this matters. Roy's prose is dense and stylistically rich, and her meanings often sit in word choice and rhythm as much as in plot. Dr Sharma's writing is plainer but rewards attention to how he stages conversations inside families and how he places the law in ordinary scenes. Close reading is the foundation on which all other analysis rests.

The close reading is guided by three theoretical frameworks, set out in detail in the Theoretical Overview. These are feminist theory, postcolonial feminist criticism, and feminist legal studies. The thesis does not use these frameworks as templates into which the texts are forced. It uses them as lenses, picked up when they help and put down when they do not. A scene of marital conflict in Roy's novel may call for Butler on gender performance and Sunder Rajan on the figure of the Indian woman in the same paragraph. A scene of police inquiry in Dr Sharma's *498A: Fears and Dreams* may call mainly for Basu and Agnes on how Section 498A actually works in practice. The choice of lens follows the text, not the other way around.

The third method is comparative. This study is built around the move of placing Dr Sharma and Roy side by side. The comparison is not symmetrical, since the two writers come from different positions and have different concerns, but the asymmetry is part of what the study is interested in. The comparative method here means reading scenes, themes, and devices from one author next to the other, asking what each reveals about the other, and noticing where they converge and where they pull apart. The comparison is organised by theme, such as marriage, domestic violence, female agency, law, and social reform, rather than by chronology or by author. This is what allows both writers to share the same chapters rather than being kept in separate rooms.

The fourth element of the methodology is the integration of primary literary texts with secondary critical and theoretical material. The six primary texts are the centre of the work.

Around them sit two layers of secondary material. The first layer is the existing literary scholarship on Dr Sharma and on Roy, which has been mapped in the literature review. This layer is consulted both to position the present study and to be argued with. The second layer is the theoretical and feminist legal literature, drawn from Butler, Menon, Sunder Rajan, Basu, Agnes, Uberoi, and others. This layer provides the conceptual vocabulary the thesis uses to read its texts. A small third layer of legal and journalistic material on Section 498A and on domestic violence in India is also consulted as context, but it does not become an object of literary analysis in its own right.

The thesis is interpretive rather than empirical. It does not conduct surveys, interviews, or field work. It does not gather statistics on domestic violence cases or court outcomes. Where such data matters, it is drawn from the existing work of legal scholars and sociologists, especially Basu. The contribution of this study is a careful, structured reading of the chosen texts, not the production of new social scientific data.

A final word on the question of citation and originality. The work is carried out from the primary texts outwards. Every reading begins with the actual sentences of the novels and essays, and the theoretical and critical material is brought in only where it does work. All citations follow MLA 9th edition, with primary and secondary sources kept separate in the Works Cited. No passage from any secondary source is reproduced beyond brief quotation, and the analysis throughout is in the researcher's own words.

The methods just described are simple in name but demanding in practice. They depend on patient reading, on disciplined comparison, and on careful handling of theory. The chapters that follow are organised so that these methods can do their work at length and in detail.

TENTATIVE CHAPTERIZATION

The thesis is structured in nine chapters. The first three set up the project. The next two introduce the work of each author in turn. The three after that carry out the comparative reading of the six primary texts, organised by theme. The final chapter draws the threads together and states the contribution.

Chapter 1: Introduction

The opening chapter introduces the project. It states the central argument, that the Indian home in the fiction of Dr Vikas Sharma and Arundhati Roy is a battleground where marital conflict, gendered injury, and the contradictions of law and reform are played out. It introduces the two authors and the six primary texts in brief. It explains why a comparative reading of a male and a female contemporary Indian writer is needed at this moment in Indian literary criticism. It maps the architecture of the thesis and locates the work within the discipline of Indian English literary studies.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

The second chapter surveys the existing scholarship on Dr Vikas Sharma and Arundhati Roy in detail, alongside the wider conversation in Indian feminist literary criticism and feminist legal studies that touches both writers. It groups the existing work into three clusters: studies of Dr Sharma, studies of Roy, and the surrounding work on marriage, law, and patriarchy in Indian fiction and scholarship. It evaluates what each piece of scholarship has done well and what it has left undone. The chapter ends by naming the gap that the present thesis enters: no prior comparison of Dr Sharma and Roy, no sustained feminist or legal reading of Dr Sharma's work, a drift away from the domestic in recent Roy criticism, and no comparative work across a male and a female contemporary Indian author.

Chapter 3: Theoretical Framework and Methodology

The third chapter sets out the three theoretical traditions that guide the analysis and the working methods of the thesis. The three traditions are feminist theory (drawing on Judith Butler and Nivedita Menon), postcolonial feminist criticism (drawing on Rajeswari Sunder Rajan), and feminist legal studies (drawing on Srimati Basu, Flavia Agnes, and Patricia Uberoi). The chapter explains how these frameworks are used as lenses rather than as templates, and how

close reading, comparative reading by theme, and the integration of literary and legal-feminist material come together as the methods of the thesis. It also sets out the principles of citation and originality that govern the work.

Chapter 4: The Fiction of Dr Vikas Sharma

The fourth chapter offers a sustained critical reading of Dr Vikas Sharma's three primary texts: *498A: Fears and Dreams*, *Ashes and Fire*, and *Love's Not Time's Fool*. It situates these novels in the world of contemporary Indian academic and middle class fiction, with attention to their setting, their style, and their concerns. It reads the three novels in order, tracing how each one handles the central questions of marriage, family, and law in its own way. The chapter sets out what is distinctive about Dr Sharma's treatment of the Indian home before the later chapters bring his work into comparison with Roy.

Chapter 5: The Fiction of Arundhati Roy

The fifth chapter offers a sustained critical reading of Arundhati Roy's three primary texts: *The God of Small Things*, *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness*, and *My Seditious Heart*. It situates these works in the wider landscape of Indian English fiction and political non-fiction. It reads the two novels and the essay collection in turn, tracing how Roy handles marriage, the household, caste, and the state across her body of work. The chapter sets out what is distinctive about Roy's treatment of the Indian home, with particular attention to the domestic and marital terrain that recent Roy criticism has tended to push to the side.

Chapter 6: Marital Conflict and the Architecture of the Household

The sixth chapter takes up the first thread of the title: marital conflict. It reads scenes of disagreement, disappointment, and quiet violence from Dr Sharma's three novels and Roy's three texts side by side. In Dr Sharma it follows the everyday conflicts of middle class marriages, the role of in-laws, dowry, suspicion, and the question of compatibility. In Roy it follows Ammu's marriage and divorce in *The God of Small Things*, the broken marriages in *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness*, and Roy's wider treatment of marriage in *My Seditious Heart*. The chapter uses Butler on gender performance and Menon on the family as a political institution to read these scenes, and argues that both writers treat the home as a place where larger social forces meet inside ordinary lives.

Chapter 7: Law, Section 498A, and the Politics of Gender Justice

The seventh chapter focuses on the second thread of the title: gender justice. It places Dr Sharma's *498A: Fears and Dreams* at its centre and reads the novel through Srimati Basu's ethnographic work on family courts and Flavia Agnes's defence of Section 498A. It traces how the law enters the household in the novel and what it does to husbands, wives, in-laws, and the wider family. Alongside this reading, the chapter examines how Roy's fiction and essays treat law and the state, especially in *The God of Small Things*, where the policing of the love laws turns deadly, and in *My Seditious Heart*, where the law is shown as both protector and aggressor. Rajeswari Sunder Rajan's work on the postcolonial state holds the literary and legal readings together.

Chapter 8: Female Agency, Resistance, and the Question of Social Reform

The eighth chapter takes up the third thread of the title: social reform. It moves from how the home and the law constrain women to how women in these texts find or fail to find ways to act. In Dr Sharma's *Ashes and Fire* it reads Suvidha's choices in detail. In *Love's Not Time's Fool* it asks what kind of agency is possible within a marriage that survives rather than breaks. In Roy's *The God of Small Things* it reads Ammu's love affair as both refusal and disaster. In *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* it reads Anjum's community in the graveyard as an alternative form of household. In *My Seditious Heart* it follows Roy's arguments about reform, protest, and the limits of state action. Menon and Uberoi are used to hold the historical question of reform in view.

Chapter 9: Conclusion

The ninth and final chapter draws together the findings of the close readings and states the contribution of the thesis. It returns to the four gaps identified in the literature review and shows how each has been addressed. It restates the central argument in light of the textual evidence assembled in chapters 4 through 8. It reflects on what the comparative method has revealed that single author studies could not. It suggests directions for further research, including the possibility of extending the comparison to other contemporary Indian writers and the legal-literary readings that could follow from this work.

Read together, the nine chapters move from setting up the question, through the building of the theoretical and methodological apparatus, through the dedicated treatment of each author's

work, into a three stage thematic comparative reading, and finally to a synthesis that names what the comparative method has produced.

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